might avoid any confrontation whatever. It reduced the length of time this secret would have to stay bottled up inside our government. Moreover, Bundy argued, consider the alternatives—each called for springing the discovery on Khrushchev when announcing to the American people and the world the chosen course of action. This amounted to a suspension of the rules of diplomacy. To make this a public issue engaging Khrushchev's and the Soviets' prestige in the eyes of the world, before trying traditional diplomatic channels, would be at best shortsighted. Finally, in terms of the argument that became the touchstone of these deliberations, a diplomatic approach closed no other options. If Khrushchev refused or delayed, an alternative could then be publicly announced, and the Administration would be shielded from criticisms that it had provoked the public confrontation without first attempting diplomatic negotiations.

Bundy's argument was powerful. But the tone of the argument and the fact that later in the week he became an advocate of the air strike leaves some doubt about his "real" reaction. Was he laboring under his acknowledged burden of responsibility in the fiasco at the Bay of Pigs? Was he playing the role of devil's advocate in order to make the President probe his own initial reaction? As Bundy summarized his own reaction, "I almost deliberately stayed in the minority. I felt that it was very important to keep the President's choices open."

Robert Kennedy saw the political wall against which Khrushchev had backed his brother. But he found himself hemmed in by two additional barriers as well. First, like McNamara, he was haunted by the prospect of nuclear doom. Was Khrushchev going to force the President into an insane act? Second, more than any other member of the group, he saw a vital issue posed by the traditions and moral position of the United States. Was his brother going to blacken the name of the United States in the pages of history? Recall his scribbled note at the first meeting of the Ex Comm: "I now know how Tojo felt when he was planning Pearl Harbor." From the outset he probed for an alternative to the air strike.

The initial reaction of Theodore Sorensen fell somewhere between the President and his brother. Like the President, Sorensen felt the sting of betrayal. If the President had been the architect of the policy the missiles punctured, Sorensen was the draftsman. Khrushchev's deceitful move demanded a strong countermove. But like Robert Kennedy, Sorensen feared lest shock and disgrace lead to disaster. Chosen by the President to be his primary reporter on the discussions in the Ex Comm, Sorensen guarded against becoming an advocate. Instead, in the Ex